



W. Alex Foxworthy, Ph.D.

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To the UVA's Environmental Institute Climate Collaborative Program Manager:

I am writing to express my strong support for the proposal led by Dr. Majid Shafiee-Jood at the University of Virginia to establish a community-anchored research initiative focused on climate-resilient wastewater solutions in coastal and rural regions. As a science faculty member at Eastern Shore Community College (ESCC), I have witnessed firsthand the urgency of the septic system failures and water quality challenges facing our communities, particularly under intensifying climate stress. I believe this project represents a timely, meaningful, and deeply needed step toward empowering communities on the Eastern Shore and beyond with the knowledge, tools, and partnerships needed to drive equitable infrastructure transitions.

I am excited to collaborate with the UVA team on this important effort, building on our ongoing partnership through the NSF Coastlines and People Climate Equity project, in several capacities. First, I will provide mentorship and guidance for the development of an internship and capstone engagement program that connects ESCC students with the UVA research team and local agencies. Our science program includes a capstone course requirement that can flexibly accommodate applied research or service-learning experiences. Building on successful past experiences, we envision engaging students in field monitoring, community engagement, and decision-support activities related to wastewater infrastructure, with a special emphasis on projects that are rooted in the Eastern Shore's unique environmental and social landscape. These internships will not only provide experiential learning for our students, but also expand local capacity for data collection, public health outreach, and applied research. I look forward to working with ESCC colleagues such as Hayleigh Bradbury to identify strong student candidates and help structure meaningful, mentored experiences.

Second, I will serve in a liaison role between the research team and Eastern Shore communities. My longstanding relationships with students, families, and local

organizations position me to support early and ongoing dialogue with residents about septic system performance, perceived risks, monitoring options, and potential infrastructure transitions. These conversations are often difficult, particularly when trust in public institutions is low and the technical language surrounding wastewater infrastructure can be confusing or intimidating. As a local educator and advocate, I can help translate between the lived experience of residents and the goals of the research team, fostering a two-way exchange that supports transparency, understanding, and co-creation of solutions.

Finally, I am excited about the broader vision of this project and its commitment to capacity-building for future environmental leaders on the Shore. By bridging community colleges, research universities, and local government, this initiative opens up new pathways for rural students to meaningfully engage in science and policy, while also ensuring that their knowledge and experiences shape the future of infrastructure planning in their own communities. I believe ESCC can play a key role in this effort, and I am committed to working closely with Dr. Shafiee-Jood and his team to realize this shared vision.

Please do not hesitate to reach out if further information or clarification is needed.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to be 'W. Alex Foxworthy', with a long horizontal stroke extending to the right.

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